

Editor Brief — When Advertising Feels Like Friendship

October 4, 2026 · Rathan Vijearajah

Overview

Cut an 8–9 minute YouTube-style video essay from three inputs: Rathan's footage, AI B-roll and 80 finished 4K motion graphics. Rathan's face carries the video. Graphics appear only where they show something words can't.

Item	Spec
Runtime	7–10 min target. The final script is 1,226 words: about 8:34 at 155 words per minute, including the title and visual-only beats.
Frame	16:9, 3840×2160, 30 fps
Presenter	Rathan Vijearajah. Their face must appear in the video (submission requirement).
Style	Polished YouTube essay, not a classroom slideshow. Dark graphics, cream type, one red accent.
Graphics balance (core cut)	About 54% Rathan on screen (4.6 min), 16% AI B-roll, 30% graphics. More once each graphic beat opens on Rathan.

The one rule: every graphic must move the argument forward. If a graphic only repeats the line being spoken, cut it and stay on Rathan.

Files

All 80 graphics are in one folder, `motion-graphics/out/`, named by the IDs used in this brief (for example `B20-ThreeYearsOneSecond.mp4`). Download the whole set as one zip (about 450 MB, GitHub sign-in needed): [branch zip](#).

What	Where	Notes
Full-screen graphics	<code>out/*.mp4</code>	H.264, 4K, 30 fps. Each animates in, then holds its last frame, so trim the tail to the voiceover.
Overlays	<code>out/*-ALPHA.mov</code>	Lossless PNG in MOV with transparency. Put them on a track above the footage.
Stills	<code>out/stills/</code>	One 4K still per graphic, for thumbnails or freeze frames

What	Where	Notes
Edit sheet	<code>motion-graphics/storyboard/When-Advertising-Feels-Like-Friendship-Edit-Sheet.pdf</code>	Full script with the file for every line
Rathan's footage	From Rathan	Commercial, casual YouTube version, talking head, monitor push-in
AI B-roll	From Rathan (Higgsfield)	Set reveal, lifestyle montage, sports-drink ad, beauty creator, fitness creator, young viewer

ID prefixes: `01 – 32` and `Q1 – Q7` come from the script, `B01 – B29` from the storyboard, `C01 – C12` are chapter cards.

Premiere setup

The graphics are already tested in Premiere: the overlays import with working transparency. Five setups need specific settings:

- Sequence:** 3840×2160 at 30 fps. Drag any `.mp4` from the set onto New Item to match the settings.
- YouTube window (`B01`):** put Rathan's casual clip on the track below. Motion: Position **1400, 857.5**, Scale **64.6**. It then sits exactly inside the player hole.
- Phone portal (`B28` + `B29`):** stack the tracks as follows. Both files share the same motion.
 - V1: outgoing clip
 - V2: incoming clip, with Track Matte Key set to Matte V3 and Composite using Matte Alpha
 - V3: `B29` (the matte)
 - V4: `B28` (the phone bezel)
- Final stack (`B27`):** text only. Add an Essential Graphics rectangle under it with a linear gradient, black on the left fading to transparent at about two-thirds of the width.
- Playback:** the 4K lossless overlays are heavy. Use 1/2 or 1/4 playback resolution, or proxies. Neither affects the export.

Edit approach

Work in three passes and send Rathan an export after each one.

- Radio cut:** lay Rathan's voiceover or talking head end to end, tighten the pauses, and lock the runtime. Every timecode in this brief is an estimate until this pass is done.
- Core cut:** add the graphics and AI shots marked Core in the beat plan below. Every beat marked You stays on Rathan.
- Polish:** sound, colour and captions. Don't swap in the backup graphics without asking Rathan.

Pacing rules:

- Open each graphic beat on Rathan's face, then cut to the graphic on the word it illustrates.

- Let a graphic finish its animation before cutting away. Trim the held last frame, not the motion.
- Never more than two full-screen graphics in a row without Rathan's face or B-roll between them.
- Lines in the beat plan with no graphic are Rathan's opinions. Keep them on Rathan's face.
- Chapter cards (c01 – c12) are optional. Use them only if the cut needs a breather, and then use all of them so they're consistent.

Beat plan

Every line of the final script (`When_Advertising_Feels_Like_Friendship.docx`) in order, with what goes on screen. Times are estimates; slide them to the radio cut. Core = use the graphic. You = stay on Rathan's face; any graphic listed on a You row is a backup only. The full lines are in the script document.

01 • OPENING (0:00-1:00)

Time	Line	On screen	Use
0:00	Think about this for a second. If a random person appears ...	B02-AdvertisementLabel-ALPHA.mov ; Footage: fake commercial, ending with the bottle pushed into the lens; Alt: 02	Core
0:12	But what if it's someone you've been watching online for three ...	AI: set reveal, pulling back from the bottle to show the lights, stands and monitor	AI shot
0:17	They're doing their morning routine, talking about their skin, maybe showing ...	B01-YouTubeWindow-ALPHA.mov ; B25-CommentsPop-ALPHA.mov ; Footage: casual YouTube version; Alt: Q1 , B28	Core
0:32	That feels different. It doesn't really feel like an ad anymore. ...	03-NotAnAd.mp4	You
0:41	(no voiceover, about 4 s, music only)	B05-SplitLabels-ALPHA.mov ; Footage: split screen, commercial left and YouTube version right; Alt: B03 , B04	Core
0:45	And that's exactly why influencer marketing is so powerful. Brands aren't ...	Footage: talking head, then hard cut to B06-TrustOnBlack.mp4 on "Trust."; Alt: 04	Core
0:55	(no voiceover)	B07-TitlePresenter.mp4 ; Alt: 01	Core

02 • WHY THIS WORKS (1:00-1:39)

Time	Line	On screen	Use
1:00	A big part of why this works comes down to something ...	B09-TermLowerThird-ALPHA.mov ; B08-NameLowerThird-ALPHA.mov ; Footage: talking head	Core
1:06	Basically, it's a one-sided relationship where you feel like you know ...	06-OneWayRelationship.mp4 ; Alt: 05	Core
1:14	And social media is almost built for this. You see creators ...	B10-CalendarFill-ALPHA.mov ; AI: lifestyle montage, 2-4 s per clip (morning, getting ready, breakfast, travel); Alt: 07	Core
1:28	So after a while, they stop feeling like strangers. They start ...	Footage: talking head, then B12-EvidenceCard1.mp4 ; Alt: 08	Core

03 • TRADITIONAL ADS VS. INFLUENCER ADS (1:39-2:22)

Time	Line	On screen	Use
1:39	Think about how different that is from a normal commercial. If ...	Footage: talking head; AI: generic drink commercial, unbranded; Alt: 09	AI shot
1:54	Influencer advertising can be way more subtle. You could be watching ...	AI: beauty creator morning routine (coffee, outfit, skincare), or reuse the casual YouTube version; Alt: Q2	AI shot
2:11	Now the ad is sitting inside normal content. It doesn't interrupt ...	10-AdInsideContent.mp4 ; Alt: B15	Core

04 • WHERE IT STARTS TO GET UNCOMFORTABLE (2:22-3:08)

Time	Line	On screen	Use
2:22	That's where things start getting a little uncomfortable. Because from a ...	11-BuiltOverYears.mp4 ; Alt: B16	You
2:38	So when a company pays them to promote something, that company ...	12-BorrowedTrust.mp4	Core
2:51	And the language usually doesn't sound like advertising either. It sounds ...	13-AdLanguage.mp4 ; Alt: Q3 , Q4 , Q5	You

05 • THE RESEARCH (3:08-4:02)

Time	Line	On screen	Use
3:08	When I started looking into the research, I didn't just want ...	Footage: talking head	Footage
3:18	I wanted to understand why people trust influencers so much, whether ...	14-ResearchQuestions.mp4	You
3:31	So I focused on research around parasocial relationships, credibility, sponsored content, ...	B26-SearchTerms.mp4 ; Alt: 15	You
3:37	And one of the biggest patterns that comes up is that ...	B13-EvidenceCard2.mp4 ; Alt: 16	Core
3:47	Which makes sense. You're probably going to take a recommendation more ...	Footage: talking head	Footage

06 • BEAUTY INFLUENCERS (4:02-4:41)

Time	Line	On screen	Use
4:02	Take beauty influencers. Imagine you've watched the same creator for two ...	AI: beauty creator, year 1, mild acne, trying products	AI shot
4:15	Then one day they show you a serum and say: "This ...	AI: same creator, year 2, clearer skin, serum to camera; Alt: Q6	AI shot
4:22	That statement has history behind it. You're not just evaluating the ...	17-BeautyTimeline.mp4	Core

Time	Line	On screen	Use
4:32	That makes the recommendation more powerful. The same product shown in ...	Footage: reuse the fake commercial from the opening	Footage

07 • FITNESS INFLUENCERS (4:41-5:19)

Time	Line	On screen	Use
4:41	The same thing happens in fitness. Maybe you follow someone because ...	AI: fitness creator working out, then seated with the supplement	AI shot
4:53	Now you're not looking at that supplement completely objectively. Your opinion ...	18-TrustTransfer.mp4	You
5:05	Then maybe there's a discount code. A link in the bio. ...	B18-CheckoutFlow.mp4 ; Alt: 19	You
5:14	Watch. Trust. Click. Buy.	20-WatchTrustClickBuy.mp4 ; Alt: B24	Core

08 • WHAT BRANDS ARE REALLY BUYING (5:19-5:50)

Time	Line	On screen	Use
5:19	And that's why brands love influencer marketing. They're not just buying ...	B19-BrandFlow.mp4 ; Alt: 21	Core
5:33	Because a brand might take years to build trust with a ...	22-YearsVsAlready.mp4	You
5:40	So instead of saying: "Trust our company." The brand is basically ...	23-TrustSwap.mp4	You

09 • WHAT ABOUT DISCLOSURE? (5:50-6:38)

Time	Line	On screen	Use
5:50	But then there's the obvious question. What about sponsorship disclosure? Influencers ...	B17-DisclosureZoom.mp4 , then 24-DisclosureLabels.mp4	Core
6:01	And that definitely matters. People should know when money is involved. ...	Footage: talking head	Footage
6:13	If you've trusted someone for three years, seeing the word "ad" ...	B20-ThreeYearsOneSecond.mp4 ; Alt: 25	Core
6:21	You might actually think: "Yeah, they're getting paid, but they wouldn't ...	Q7-YouThinking.mp4	You
6:28	And that's exactly the point. The disclosure tells you there's a ...	B14-EvidenceCard3.mp4 ; Alt: 25	Core

10 • THE COUNTERARGUMENT (6:38-7:13)

Time	Line	On screen	Use
6:38	Now, influencer marketing isn't automatically bad. There are real benefits. Small ...	26-Benefits.mp4 ; optional B-roll of a small shop or a creator editing	You
6:55	So the issue isn't simply: Influencers get paid, therefore influencer marketing ...	27-TooSimple.mp4	You

Time	Line	On screen	Use
7:01	The bigger issue is what happens when the creator's relationship with ...	B21-RentListing.mp4 ; Alt: 28	Core

11 • YOUNGER AUDIENCES (7:13-7:50)

Time	Line	On screen	Use
7:13	And this becomes even more important with younger audiences. If someone ...	B22-DayMonthYear-ALPHA.mov ; Al: young viewer in a dim bedroom watching a creator on a laptop	Core
7:25	They talk directly to the camera. They respond to comments. They ...	29-GrewUp.mp4	You
7:35	So when they recommend something, it can be harder to separate: ...	B23-PersonProductMorph.mp4 ; Alt: 30	Core

12 • CONCLUSION (7:50-8:34)

Time	Line	On screen	Use
7:50	So what's really being sold here? Obviously the product. But not ...	B27-FinalStackOverlay-ALPHA.mov over the opening commercial and YouTube frame; Alt: 31	Core
8:03	That's what makes influencer marketing different from a traditional ad. The ...	Footage: talking head	Footage
8:13	And once advertising starts feeling like friendship, we probably need to ...	Footage: talking head, slow push-in	Footage
8:21	Because sometimes the most valuable thing in the entire deal isn't ...	32-Ending.mp4 , then 2 s of black	Core

Sound

Music carries the essay, but silence makes the key moments land.

Moment	Time	Treatment
Fake commercial	0:00	Glossy ad-style bed, a bit too polished on purpose
YouTube version	0:17	Switch to a soft, casual lo-fi bed. The contrast is the point.
Cut to black on "Trust."	0:55	Kill all music. Two beats of silence, then the title comes in with the main theme.
Watch. Trust. Click. Buy.	5:14	Four hard hits, one per word
Disclosure freeze (B17)	5:50	Hard stop or tape-stop on the freeze
"Too simple" stamp (27)	6:55	One stamp hit
"Rented" (B21)	7:01	A beat of silence after "rented by a brand"
Counterargument	6:38	Lighter bed. It signals fairness.

Moment	Time	Treatment
"More critical about what we're watching"	8:13	Pull the music down under the line
Last line, then black	8:21	Music out with the cut to black, 2 s of silence

Keep the music under the voice at about –18 to –20 dB, and mix dialogue to about –14 LUFS integrated for YouTube. Small ticks or whooshes on graphics are fine, but no more than one per graphic.

Open items, don'ts and delivery

Two things are still open before picture lock. Everything else is ready to cut.

- ☐ Source B12 – B14 show the citation only. Rathana supplies the one-sentence finding for each, and the cards get re-rendered with it.
- ☐ Give the editor access to the files: GitHub access to the private repo, or send the zip another way.

Don'ts:

- Don't generate text, logos, prices or real brands with AI. All on-screen text comes from the graphics or Premiere.
- Don't use an AI version of Rathana as the main talking head. AI shots are B-roll only.
- Don't scale, stretch or recolour the graphics. They're built for 3840×2160 and the palette is fixed.
- Don't add stock transitions between graphics. Use straight cuts, or the transitions named in the beat plan.

Review rounds:

Round	What Rathana reviews	Export
1	Radio cut: runtime and pacing	1080p H.264, burned-in timecode
2	Core cut: graphics and AI shots in place	1080p H.264, burned-in timecode
3	Polish: optional graphics, sound, colour, captions	1080p H.264
Final	Sign-off	4K master

Feedback comes back as timecoded notes, one note per change.

Final delivery:

- 4K master: 3840×2160, 30 fps, H.264 at about 45–68 Mbps, AAC stereo 48 kHz at 320 kbps
- Captions as an .srt file
- Submission checklist: the video link, the script, a bibliography, at least 2 academic sources cited on screen, Rathana's name on screen and their face in the video